# NASA's Swift Telescope Falls to Earth

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One of NASA's famous space **telescopes** has fallen back to Earth. The Swift Observatory came down on Wednesday after 22 years in space. It studied the biggest **explosions** in the universe. Swift fell near Indonesia, the U.S. Space Force said. Strong activity from the **Sun** had pulled it lower over the past few years. NASA tried to save it. The space agency asked a private company, Katalyst Space, to build a **rescue** craft that would push Swift higher. But the craft had trouble after it **launched** in July and crashed in September. No one knows yet how much burned up, but NASA thinks some heavier pieces made it to the ground. Swift **launched** in 2004. Its job was meant to last only two years, but it kept working for 22 years. It watched thousands of huge space **explosions** called **gamma-ray** bursts. Now NASA wants to save another famous **telescope**, Hubble, which **launched** in 1990 and may fall by the mid-2030s. "Hubble still has important science ahead of it," said NASA chief Jared Isaacman.

## Word Treasure

**telescope** -- A telescope is a tool for looking at faraway things in space.
**explosions** -- An explosion is a sudden burst of energy.
**Sun** -- The Sun is the star at the centre of our Solar System.
**rescue** -- A rescue is saving something from danger.
**gamma-ray** -- Gamma rays are a kind of powerful light from space.
**launched** -- Launched means sent off, like a rocket taking off.

## Background you need

A space telescope looks at the universe from above Earth's air.

The Sun can heat the air high above Earth and pull low satellites down.

## Break it down

**WHO:** NASA, the U.S. Space Force and Katalyst Space
**WHAT:** The Swift telescope fell back to Earth
**WHERE:** Near Indonesia
**WHY:** Strong activity from the Sun pulled its orbit lower

## Why it matters

Telescopes in space help us learn about the universe, so it matters when one falls down.

## Test what you remember

**1. How long did Swift work in space?**

- (A) 22 years
- (B) 11 years
- (C) 30 years
- (D) 2 years

**2. Where did Swift fall?**

- (A) Near Indonesia
- (B) Near Brazil
- (C) Near Australia
- (D) Near the Moon

**3. What did Swift study?**

- (A) The surface of the Moon
- (B) The rings of Saturn
- (C) The weather on Mars
- (D) The biggest explosions in the universe

**4. What pulled Swift's orbit lower?**

- (A) A software mistake
- (B) Strong activity from the Sun
- (C) A crash with another satellite
- (D) A broken solar panel

**5. What happened to the rescue craft?**

- (A) It had trouble and crashed in September
- (B) It never launched
- (C) It is still in space
- (D) It lifted Swift higher

**6. What did NASA chief Jared Isaacman say about Hubble?**

- (A) Hubble is too old to fix
- (B) Hubble should be switched off
- (C) Hubble still has important science ahead of it
- (D) Hubble will fall tomorrow

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: D 4: B 5: A 6: C

# Questions to think about

## 1. NASA chief Jared Isaacman: says Hubble still has important science ahead of it

### MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):